

IV The Queen's Potion

O *ballanbilaigonds, dungonitands* stupid you! You should have refused the cup he had offered. For you immediately feel funny. And it is not just the alcohol that makes you giddy. Yet, while it sounds a bit like the Hunnic curse, it is kind of the opposite. Not him, half-Hun, is affected by it, but you. Are you then to die? Is this then the end of your Gothic tale?

—"What potion is this, you gave me!?"

—"Don't worry, Your Grace, it makes all your dreams come to you." Did he mean to say, all dreams come true?

—"What is that supposed to mean?"

—"Like last night, when I saw your visit."

—"You drank this, last night? What is it anyway?"

—"It's uhm ... a secret, one that I am tasked with safeguarding," and adding in an apologetic tone, "I only take some when it is really necessary, you know." Secret alright, for when his mother had asked for wine, he had failed to mention this ... this potion. Not knowing what exactly to ask, you just blurt out

—"What then was so necessary that you took it last night?"

—"Because, you had not collected your cups yet, Your Grace, so I wanted to see when you would. And behold, here you are, the Aryan princess of my dreams!" It doesn't make much sense, especially since you are no princess. But you kind of have given up on arguing that point with him. Perhaps you don't want to disappoint him. He is actually kind of nice. Although raving mad! And possibly a practitioner of gothocide! Your legs are wobbling, so, you have to sit down again. The storm outside is no longer raging furiously, but it is still raining too hard to attempt an escape. Somehow, you have accepted your lot. *Fiat quod erit* [what will be, will be].

—"Who then is the owner of this concoction, this swig you made me drink?" He gives you a timid glance and mutters

—"The *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn's*?" Not Hunnic but Turkic the potion is? If that is already different, for nobody seems to agree on where all those Huns and Turk come from. But the word is that *Shāhān-Shāh* Hormozd's mother was some northern Turk, while his second wife, was some eastern Turk. Same difference, the scandalmongers would add.

—"The dowager *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*?"

—"No, no. Our own *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*! Lady Spahbedān." So, Persian magic then. No clue though whether that is better or worse.

—“Why then do you keep it here?”

—“Well, I am not telling it right. Its history is a little... twisted.” You tilt your head towards the door. Still raining cats and dogs!

—“It seems I am going to be here for a while, so why don’t you regale me with its tale.” You pat the little carpet you are sitting on, and he sits down next to you—somehow, you are no longer afraid of him—the joint escape from the bowels of the *dewān* seems to have created some kind of comradely bond.

—“Very well, Your Grace. It is perhaps time that I unburden myself with its provenance. You see, I never told anyone this...” He stops, staring just at his mother who is still blissfully sleeping off her crapulence. After a few minutes of silence, you prod him

—“... but now you’re going to bare your soul.” He looks up from his torpor.

—“Ah, yes. It all started two decades ago, when we received a crate of figs. At that time, I was still an apprentice and I was assigned to the *dewān* of the Lost Causes.” That sounds menacing.

—“Wat is that?”

—“Oh, it’s where we keep everything that is lost...” That doesn’t make much sense.

—“How can you keep it if you lost it?”

—“Oh, ha, ha. I did not say that right, didn’t I? I meant, everything that arrives at the palace, but no one remembers anymore what or whom it was for. You see, often the shipping bill gets lost—peasants are not very good with shipping bills—or there never was one, or someone forgot to edit the ledgers at the *darigbed*’s office and now there is no mention of the shipment. Like this crate of figs. And so, the handymen don’t know where to deliver it and they bring it to us, I mean to the *dewān* of the Lost Causes. And then we are tasked to find out whose this was supposed to be. But that is not easy and a lot of things that arrive there, never leave the *dewān*.”

—“But not those figs. Although, how did they then turn into wine?”

—“Indeed, the only thing we knew at the time was that they originated somewhere from within the Halwān district. But why they were sent here and upon whose orders remained unclear. Now, as you can imagine, a lot of those Lost Causes are perishables and therefore have to be thrown out. But there is so much—you can’t imagine how much gets misplaced over here... the slovenliness of the court is proverbial,” you can agree with that: whenever Mariam sees a shoe or a boot and decides she is going to

wear it to dinner that night, it takes hours before you can locate its twin, “and things were even worse in those days before Lord Wahrām reorganized the system. And so, those figs, they sat there for several years. By foresight or by divine intervention, I had already transferred them from their original crate into an earthen vessel. And so, when I finally happened upon them again, they had fermented into this wine. I dipped my finger in it, expecting it to be sour, but it tasted so sweet. And then that night, in a dream, I saw where they had come from. From an orchard in the Alwand valley. A royal estate, no less. When, the next day, I inquired with my colleague in the *dewān* of the Imperial Immovables. . .”

—“Do you mean . . . their dead ancestors?”

—“Ha, ha, no. Immovable as in property that cannot be moved. . .”

—“Because it’s too heavy and no one can lift it up?”

—“Except a quake,” you look puzzled at him, and he smiles, “It means land, Your Grace, ha, ha.” Okay. That was stupid of you. This *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*’s potion, it makes you a little slow. But somehow you don’t care, and you laugh heartily with him—you start getting to suspect that he has taken a sip of the brew as well, before he came up the stairs with it, for he too is a bit giddy—so different from the stern master of the *dewān* [demons] you first took him for.

—“Yeah, good luck moving those around.”

—“Well, except on paper. For as it turns out, this estate belonged to the late dowager *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*, Lady Newānduxt,” you have heard of her: she was the mother of the late *Shāhān-Shāh* Husrow Anushag-ruwān, “And when she passed, those estates were inherited by the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*, Lady Spahbedān—the grandniece of Lady Newānduxt. . .” You didn’t know they were related.

—“You mean that they were from the same house?”

—“Oh, yes, Your Grace, as long as memory goes, house Spahbedān has always married into house Sasān. Perhaps one day, you too will. . .,” wait, is he now implying that you are a princess descending from those Pahlav—those are the people who live in the north and they are different from the people in the south, the Pārsig, you figured out—how different you don’t really know, but they don’t like each other too much it appears—well, still enough to intermarry. . .—okay, you have to stop letting your mind wander off, “Oh, *abaχshāyid* [sorry], that makes no sense. Forget I said that, Your Grace. The whole ordeal has rattled me a little and I can’t think too straight anymore and . . . and I might also. . .” He eyes to the floor next to

him. You hadn't noticed it yet, but it's the jar—where in god's name did that come from? So, you just nod.

—"I assumed as much, ha, ha. I think it requires some *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*'s potion for an Aryan princess and the master of the *dewān* [demons?] to joke together, ha, ha."

—"Ha, ha. Well said, Your Grace... I am so glad you came... I am so lonely here, only mother..." he must have felt a little too presumptive in his sharing, for he started to apologize, shuffling a little father away from you, "*abaχshāyid* [sorry], I... I didn't mean it that way, Your Grace. I apologize if I made you feel uncomfortable."

—"Well, there is always that fig potion with which to douse any awkwardness, ha, ha."

—"I wouldn't do that, Your Grace: when taken in excess, its effects can be quite... disquieting."

—"I'll take your word for it. So, the fig groves passed from grandaunt to grandniece."

—"Well, not directly. See, royal estates can only be owned by royals, and at the time of Lady Newānduxt's passing, Lady Spahbedān, while married to *Shāhān-Shāh* Hormozd—well, at the time, he was only Crown Prince—, she was not yet considered a royal as long as she had not borne her husband a child. Now, that proved quite difficult for poor Lady Spahbedān—some say that ANĀHID herself envied her beauty and looked unfavorable upon her—but that is just pure blasphemy, ignorance of the uneducated, who think the gods are as weak as us humans—corrupted by *Hromāyig* benightedness, if you don't mind me saying so, Your Grace," that seems to get him all riled up, so you quickly shake your head: let him anathematize the Romans, you are no longer them, you are an Aryan princess now, ha, ha, "Anyway, Lady Spahbedān, she had a hard time conceiving, and it took her almost fifteen years before prince Husrow was born. And only then did she inherit the orchards, many years after the figs had been sent to us. See, in the interim, the estate had been under the custody of her brother-in-law, Lord Yazdāndād." That surprises you a little, for from what Mariam tells you about him—she calls him Yadā—, he is *Alā*, for lack of a better word, you have to quote Mariam here: simple. The one other thing you know about him is that he is Mariam's friend's father.

—"The *Shāhān-Shāh*'s brother? Chacha's father?"

—"Chacha?," yeah, that is of course not her name. Luckily, he figures it out, "Oh, you mean, princess Chahārboxt?"

—“*Abaḫshāyid*, Mariam always calls her Chacha—apparently her daddy does too.”

—“I wouldn’t know, Your Grace. But anyway, Lord Yazdāndād must have ordered those figs to be collected from the estate—uhm, Lord Yazdāndād can be a bit confused, and so, it is no surprise that he had forgotten about it. Now, as I explained, meanwhile, the figs had turned into wine. Right then, I was promoted to this *dewān*, the *dewān* of the Imperial Cutlery, and I decided to take the jar with me, and see whether I could restore it to its rightful owner. I tried in vain, but the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*’s eunuch turned down my request for its return. Apparently

~“Her Majesty does not fancy moldy wine. She prefers fermented mare’s milk.” If you ask me, that sourpuss does not deserve serving Her Majesty.” Ignoring his veiled jealousy, you inquire about that other drink.

—“Fermented mare’s milk? What is that?”

—“I don’t know, Your Grace. I guess, our *mowbed* use it in their purification ceremonies—like they do with *gomez*—and they add *hom* to it. Or something like that, I am no *mowbed*, so I wouldn’t really know.” You have heard of *gomez* before: it’s the urine of a cow. Persian theurgy is weird. Although, being currently under its influence, it makes you just giggle.

—“And so, you, scorned by the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* [Queen of Queens],” his drooping shoulders—it is clear he fancies his *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*—only a fool wouldn’t—she is so gorgeous, you even might...—*pargast*, what is it with this fig wine...—so, you correct yourself, “or at least her servant, you decided to keep this elixir to yourself.” He nods bashfully.

—“Your Grace, uhm... can we perhaps keep this between us?”

—“Of course, what happens in the *dewān* stays in the *dewān*, ha, ha. And so, now, once in a while you let yourself be intoxicated by its magic,” you poke him in his side—lowering your inhibitions is kind of invigorating, hee, hee, “But a little more of it..., you say...?”

—“As I told you, Your Grace, not recommended. The first time I tried, not knowing yet its effects, I witnessed my three fathers, ..., those Hunnic brutes, while they were... you know,” he lets out a big sob, “A nightmare I now share with my poor mother. One that has driven her to this sorry state... will I one day too...?”

—“Well, she overcame all adversity and raised you to be the master of the *dewān*! You’re now the master of your own destiny!” And of the royal silverware—which begs the question what you are going to do with the four golden cups he has given you. Should you take them? Until the police

will burst into your room in the dead of the night and drag you to the dungeons: the Gothic impostor pretending to be an Aryan princess, claiming as her only defense that she was under the influence of the Queen's potion, after having survived the Hunnic curse of the *dewān* [demons / divan]! Not very believable. And also very dumb, for they do not have police here. Only scary black eunuchs.

—"You think so, Your Grace," he glances at you with a grateful look. What in the name of all saints were you thinking: to give out advice like you are a wise queen—what do you know!, "Is the curse of my barbarian ancestry lifted?"

—"Well, perhaps better heed your own words and don't drink too much of it," something else though is a bit puzzling, "How long did you say you had this wine for? How come the jar is still almost full?"

—"It's a mystery I have come to accept, Your Grace. But you're right, I should not overindulge. The more you drink, the more ominous the dream...," he stares again for several minutes at his sleeping mother, until he turns with a sudden move to you, "Your Grace, I said that I wanted to unburden myself, and in part I did, by telling you how I came about this wine. But there is another thing, weighing more than anything else on me..." He burst out in tears, which makes you now feel a little ill at ease. You would like to comfort him, but you have misread signals before—to your shame—, and so, you just sit and wait for him to finish, making just some hushing noises. He finally composes himself and continues

—"There was one other time, that I threw caution to the wind, and I drank two full cups of it, before going to sleep. But what I then witnessed, it was..." he shudders and then exclaims in anguish, "It taunts me day and night. I don't know what to do!"

—"What was it that you saw?"

—"I promised I wouldn't tell anyone..."

—"Wait. To whom did you make such promise?"

—"To the Keeper of the Castle."

—"Who is he?"

—"It's a she, Your Grace, and she is only eight year old. I think she is a princess. And she always wears a blue dress with a little tiara on her head. And she is my guide in my dreams. And it was her who told me that the figs are from the domains of her castle in Alwand..."

—"An eight-year-old girl? And she has a castle? In Alwand?"

—"Well, I inquired with my colleagues at the *dewān* of the Imperial Im-

movables, and there is no castle in the Alwand valley, only fig groves, so, yes, I guess she only exists in the dream."

—"What's her name?"

—"It sounds like sweetness in your ears, Your Grace," what is that now supposed to mean? But he continues his story, so you don't ask, "And so, she, the Keeper of the Castle, made me promise, for, she said, it was only for the eyes of *Bāmbishn* [Queen] what I saw. But since you're a princess, I guess, it is alright if I tell you, right?" You are dying to hear the story, so you nod—let's play pretend princess.

—"A *Bāmbishn*'s secret?"

—"But you have to swear you will not tell anyone else, Your Grace!"

—"I swear," as the Persians always do, "by MEHR."

—"But He is not from your faith, Your Grace. You're a *Tarsāg* [Christian], are you not? Well, I have just the right thing. Wait here!" Yeah, in your state, you are not going anywhere soon. And he is not too steadfast either, hitting his desk, which makes him wobble even more, and you giggle uncontrollably. He finally manages to grab something from one of his cabinets. It looks like a book. Bound in a very soft leather, one the Persians call *saxtag* [morocco leather]. And the parchment, it seems to be of a purple hue.

—"What is it?"

—"The Holy Scriptures of your people. Bible you call it, not? At least, I think that's what it is, for I cannot read it. But that's what people of your faith swear on, don't they?"

—"It's in Greek?"

—"No. Nor Syriac, Aramaic, Sogdian, Hebrew, *Armin* or Latin. Those I can read." He can read all those languages? So, what on earth is this one then. Curious, you open it up, but as soon as you see the inside, you drop it with a big gasp. The letters, they are Gothic runes! And they are silver!! *Ballanbilaigonds*, *dunonitands*, this is the long-lost Silver Bible, the heirloom of House Amali, *Rex Thiudareiks*'s legacy!

—"Your Grace, are you okay?"

—"This... this ... is Gothic. The Silver Bible of *Regia Amalaberga*. How... how ... did it get here?"

—"Goths? Are those not Arian?"

—"Yeah, like me."

—"Ha, ha, I see, the play on words, Your Grace. But to answer your question. Nobody knows. One day, it was there in the *dewān* of the Lost Causes.

I told you about that one, right? But who had sent it, and who the intended addressee was, we never could figure out. No one could read this script. But you can, Your Grace?"

—"It has been a long time. Let's see." You pick it back up and open it on a random page. It takes you a little before you can decipher it, but in the end, you get it

*jah jabai taihswo theina handus marzjai thuk,
afmait tho jah wairp af thus;
batizo ist auk thus ei fraqistnai ains lithiwe theinaize,
jah ni allata leik thein gadriusai in gaiainnan¹¹*

...

*And if your right hand causes you to sin,
cut it off and throw it away.
It is better for you to lose one of your members
than for your whole body to go into hell.¹²*

You remember the verse, a rather savage one. It's from the gospels. So, this certainly is a bible! This is *Rex Thiudareiks's* bible!! You can feel it. It even tingles in your hands. How is this possible?

—"Your right hand? Is that not a little harsh?"

—"I think it is a parable. Not to be taken literally."

—"So, then, swear upon this holy scripture that you will not reveal to anyone what I am about to tell you." You put your right hand on the bible—IESOUS! MARIAM! IOSEF! Are you about to sin by prying in sacred affairs—and should you instead cut your hand off? Of course, curiosity throws all caution in the wind.

—"I swea...," the nearby thunderbolt is so loud that it even wakes up his mother. But, as soon, she is back to her slumber. *Ballanbilaigonds, dungenitands*, was that storm not over yet?! You try again, clearly in defiance of the will of the gods. To *gaiainna* [hell], you are clearly doomed to go. If you are not already there, "I swear upon this holy bible that I will not reveal what I hear here to anyone. So, dear man, to whose secret have you sworn me to silence?"

—"The *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn's* secret! ...How ... how she poisoned," he shook his head, his pause only adding the dramatic effect when he contin-

¹¹Silver Bible, folio 2v.

¹²Matthew, V.30.

ued, "... her mother-in-law!" Another loud thunderbolt drowns your exasperated gasp. What more foreboding doom are the weather gods throwing at you? But more than earthly omens, it is this other-worldly revelation that renders you speechless.

—"Wha... wha?! Who...? How?"

—"Alā, this is what transpired: the Keeper of the Castle takes my hand, leading me to a room here in the palace. There, the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* mother, the *Ḥazār* princess, is lying on a bed. The rest of the room is dark, but there is a cone of light surrounding her bed. The Keeper of the Castle admonishes me to keep quiet, when a figure steps in the light.

~"Behold, the Suitor..." the Keeper of the Castle announces, and a chorus in the background echoes

~"... scorned!" The Keeper of the Castle frowns at the response, but then announces the second guest

~"Behold, the Maiden..."

~"... maltreated!" The Keeper is not too happy with that echo either, but she continues

~"Behold, the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*..."

~"... beguiled!" The Keeper shakes her head, while, in the meantime, there appears in the cone of light the face of the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*—I mean Lady Spahbedān—, radiant as ever. She looks at her two accomplices and shows them a vial. The poison within makes it glow with a green light. She lifts it up and has the Maiden add three drops into a cup. The Maiden then hands the cup to the Suitor, who rouses the old Queen mother. She looks at her three tormentors and sighs

~"Thrice loved. Twice in love. Once lived." She takes the cup—I want to warn her that it has been poisoned—but the Keeper of the Castle admonishes me

~"Do not intervene in queenly matters, milord. You are not supposed to be here, yet by some clerical error you are. So, do not make me regret not having reported your transgression to the Sisterhood." So, I keep quiet, and watch the Queen mother drink the poison. The cup falls out of her hand, and with it, the cone of light is extinguished, and all I can hear is a loud sob. The Keeper of the Castle turns to me and admonishes me in a stern tone—for an eight-year old, she can be surprisingly stern:

~"What you witnessed, you sneaky *dew*, it is for the eyes of queens only," and then a little apologetically, she adds, "I was not supposed to see it yet either. But there, it happened. For someone could not hold his liquor!"

I think she meant me," he shakes his head, "by ANĀHID! What have I done!" You don't know what to say. Could it be true? Will the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* murder her mother-in-law? You remember a story Lord Kawād told you—long time ago—it has been a while you have thought back to that time—a time you didn't know whether you were happy or sad—do you now know better?—anyway, he told you of a Persian *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*, Parushiyāti, the mother of *Shāhān-Shāh* Artashir, of days long past. And she was so jealous of her daughter-in-law, *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* Stateira, that she had her poisoned, and then forced her son to marry his two sisters. But then Lord Kawād had added.

~"Peristerá, all this was written down by some Greek author [Ktisias]. But you should always be suspicious about what those Greek write, as they always pretend, presumptuously, to be the good guys, the free-thinking democrats, the conveyors of culture and civilization. And equally eager they are to prove that whatever comes from the east is steeped in barbarianism, in despotism, in turpitude and depravity. But quite the opposite is true," and then he had veered up from his seat, "for we, Persians, have protected the world from barbarians, brought peace where there was chaos, given them law and justice, given them culture and the arts..." You had never seen him so pumped up. He would have continued his soliloquy, if a servant had not knocked on the door and asked whether everything was alright. Lord Kawād had calmed down, probably realizing that what he had been saying could sound insidious. And that it took only one zealous servant to report this to Empress Sofia, and a poisoned cup might also come his way. But that was then, and this is now, or rather, is soon to be, for the two *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* [Queen of Queens] are still alive. And although the story of the ancient queens is kind of the reverse, the gambit coming this time from the younger queen, its eerie resemblance cannot be denied. But could therefore also be its lyrical fabrication? Perhaps this Keeper of the Castle is malevolently trying to spread these rumors, to disgrace the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* with her slander—being a princess, is she then vying for the throne herself? It would be quite amazing for an eight-year-old to pull off such a cunning scheme.

But one thing the little girl did not make up: the infamous rivalry between the two *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*. It is of mythical proportions, a tale as old as the world itself: the conniving and overbearing mother-in-law. And it wouldn't be the first time that at the palace dinner tables, this queenly rivalry is rumored to be lethal. So, the whole scene might in the end be

not that far-fetched? And then you remember a second detail the veracity of which you can confirm: the glowing vial. IESOUS! MARIAM! IOSEF! That time the dowager *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn*—the *Ḫazār* queen—, when she had summoned Mariam and you, and she made you touch the vial, and it started to glow with a greenish light. That was poison! Had she tried to kill you?? And now she was going to be killed by that very same poison, by some karmic justice???

You don't know how to respond, and your companion now also has fallen silent. Your thoughts are interrupted, when in the doorway, with the obligatory thunderbolt once more accompanying the apparition—a Gothic tale gone stale, hee, hee—you hear a voice.

—“Ah, there you are! I have been looking for you for ever!” You peer in the dark—has the torch gone out again?—to see who is addressing you. But you can only see a silhouette. Of a young girl? *Pargast*, Mariam has already returned?! She surely will have a few scornful words to say! Thus ending abruptly your dark and twisty Gothic tale...